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Ann K. Clark

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ANN K. CLARK

THE GIRL: A RHETORIC OF DESIRE

The following reflections emerged in the context of teaching women's studies students, who, encountering themselves surrounded by midwestern America, were also experiencing themselves as contested terrain. Here I am attempting, not to argue or to lay out facts, but to engage in some practical rhetoric aimed at an understanding and perhaps a sort of exorcism of what I have called The Girl. The Girl is a paradigm, what used to be called a picture of human nature. But she is now nourished by a very modern kitchen: the heavy investments of corporate capitalism. Surprisingly, The Girl is not gender-specific. In a way, any of us may see ourselves through her. She takes many forms in 1987, only some of which will be named here. But I think we shall recognize her, since being recognized is particularly her forte. Let's take a look at her.

What is she like?

Blue skies, blond hair in the wind, jeans, running across a field strewn with wild flowers, *The Girl is free.* She is able to do, be and choose anything whatsoever, whatever she is offered: Swiss Formula, Helene Curtis, L'Oréal. She lives anywhere – anywhere, that is, in a democracy. This allows her democratic choice: any kind of cheeseburger, says the American Dairy Association. So she can *be* anyone. Her home is the context of no context,[1] promising us happiness if only we join her there. Her history is to have no history so that anything is possible. That enables her, being formless, to be infinitely free.

Thumb hooked in her diaper to reveal the pink-tanned baby bottom, sun-drenched by Coppertone, *The Girl is an ersatz child.* Because she is unmarked by any adventures or by any passage through the world, she is a virtual child, pure, untouched. Because she might have appeared here as well as there, there as well as anywhere else, she bears no marks of any encounter with any particular space or time. Because she is not formed (or deformed) by history, there is nothing of her definite enough, or particular enough, to serve as the basis for her judgement. Her choices are mere acts of preference according to what seems attractive. This is called her

freedom, especially her 'freedom of choice', for it appears that nothing is required of her, since nothing is requisite to her. The Girl considers herself privileged in this pure freedom. What she picks is *all up to her.* And there are so many choices. But she wants to choose what is fitting, what fits her, what makes her fit. It has to be something just a little unique. Here is a problem, but also the answer. She cannot fit choices to herself, since, but for the choices, she is empty. Hence the only alternative is agreement, to choose what promises inclusion. So, like the child, she chooses and looks to see the response.

Gazing thoughtfully at the cherry table, worrying a little about the colour co-ordinates of the six place settings, *The Girl is both homeless and always at home.* She is homeless in order to be comforted, in order to have things put right. Then she will be at home in/with her choices – of blue, of cherry, even of bathing suit. She needs comfort. Why? We'll see that later. The point is, she *likes* the things that comfort her, she likes the shimmer of that trivial choice. It's electric. 'A little mist of energy, rather like love but trivial, rather like a sense of home but apt to disappear.'[2] Otherwise she has no attention, affection or aspiration, for her personality is altogether a matter of where she fits – in the demography of the U.S. – in the demography of 200 million. She appears always . . . either at the moment of intensity when she has just been made to sparkle: 'Adriana in her Pierre Cardin, so personal, so unique' . . . or, just before, but we know it's coming: 'Adriana felt so dull, but . . .'

Knowing that she belongs to the group of all those who choose what is appropriate gives her energy, a sense of confidence. *She* knows who *she* is. These choices must be made carefully because, for her, they are literally all important. They are all she is. Because she is bare/pure/free/empty, there is no weighing of already established needs; there are no layered desires to be integrated in a complex deliberation. This is the reason her choices can only be trivial, for they can only be arbitrary. As she chooses, her choices establish her home by setting out her demographic environment. Thus her attention is attracted by the merest glint, any iridescence promising satisfaction. Flitting here and there, she focuses on the surfaces of things, taking their sparkle as the attractiveness of something essential. She is full of the flickering tiny abilities of the romanticized child. This will endear her. She knows she will be appreciated because she is so bright and earnest, because she is so attractive. She will draw an environment to her, she will *make* a home.

In love with mauve, preoccupied by squared shoulders, 'addicted' to black raspberry Frozen Yoghurt, *The Girl is entirely perceptual.* What she attends to, what is real for her and hence what she exposes to us are the aesthetic surfaces of things. Differentiation, distinctions have to do with colour, shape, taste and feel. Percepts are her reality, atomic and without history. They do not have to do, for example, with the origins or causes of objects. Like the kitten, her familiar, her eye cannot help but follow the kaleidoscopic movement of the objects surrounding her. She works at concentrating in order to make the choice that is right for her: blue or

green, peach or lavender. Doing this, she is such a surprise to herself. She can never tell what she will do next because she is unique, an individual. This unpredictability is a source of delight to her. It too shows her freedom. She is so unrepressed, irrepressible! Her newness, freshness, naïvety, shows everywhere.

The Girl incorporates an ontological vision. She represents the object as sheer appearance, as only whatever it seems. From her perspective the question whether an object will live up to its appearance can never be asked, because for her it has no other dimension. If it sparkles, it is lovely, and that loveliness is all she needs.

Dressed in 'softest celanese', her face set in the steely expression of a vice-president of New York Bank and Trust, *The Girl is sexual but she is cold.* Both sexual and asexual, she is the talisman which, conquered or possessed, confers potency. On the other hand, emulated, she activates 'the power of the weak'[3] – a whole series of exchange values. Her love is the emotional dimension of her perceptuality. She loves her rugby shorts, her cuisinart, those objects whose shapes articulate her dependent (demographic) self-definition. Her vulnerability is her emptiness, potentially resolvable into abstract, infinitely iterable attachment.

As herself the appearance of an object, The Girl is the abstract representation of flesh and blood without the idiosyncrasy, the marks of history that make a body. There are no universal bodies, but that is what The Girl is. So she *must* be, because her intimacy occurs in 'the grid of 200 million'. It is there for all of us to share; she is there for all of us. But, of course, that is impossible. Therefore she is also innocent. She smiles: 'Look at The Girl smile. The more she smiles, the more certain it is that she represents something trivial, something shocking, or something failed.'[4] Sexuality as asexuality is all of these. Sometimes she does not smile, but, seeing that she is voluptuous under the translucent fabric, we know she doesn't mean it. Her coldness lies not in her expression but in what she is, innocent or guilty, both and so neither – qualities mutually cancelled to make an abstract surface free to be painted by Revlon but not touched by individual hands.

What's going on

What I have called The Girl is, like the unicorn, a particular design with an institutional history. The unicorn unites a complex set of interpretations and is communicated in many contexts. We find it in tapestries, in poems, in fable, in medieval bestiaries, and now in window medallions and stuffed toys. It has a long history of meanings which we might come to understand by describing its features in these various contexts, then coming to see what they signify.

'The Girl' is my name for one among many diverse threads in the representation of women by late twentieth-century corporate media. I want to look at her to see what she represents and then, perhaps, what she might

be working on us. Lastly, I want to say something about why just this sort of model, defining just this realm of possibilities, should exist.

The context of no context is where The Girl invites us to live. It is the source of the freedom she represents. And I think it is also the legacy of the destruction of history as part of our lives. George Trow describes a change in the form and rhetorical structure of history as it is represented for us in television, a change from narratives of 'growth, conflict and destruction' to records of 'demographically significant preferences'.[5] But this change affects the relationship between persons and their history. Where history is the charting of changes in common characteristics, the person becomes a unit of a class rather than an actor in the adventures of a community. Beginning with 200 million, 'New History' taxonomizes to characterize the vulnerability of groups. How many Saab owners, how many Honda owners? How many runners, how many skiers, how many drinkers of imported beer, of wine, how many with parents who went to high school, how many not – and, most importantly, how do these crucial characteristics interact? Trow calls this non-history New History because history is always the way we bring our personal experience into continuity with the past: 'the interpretation of history and the mode of writing it are always methods of making history.'[6] What New History does is to remake history by denying continuity with the past. It is peculiar in that its synchronic taxonomy explicitly denies any continuities of motivation, intention or causality. Paul Ricœur writes about the connection between persons and history:

> A human being discovers his finitude in the fact that, first of all, he finds himself within a tradition or traditions. Because history precedes me and my reflection, because I belong to history before I belong to myself, prejudgment also precedes judgment and submission to tradition precedes their examination.[7]

To discover one's finitude is to discover one's boundaries and hence one's character and shape. Knowing that shape, the person one is, supplies the foundation for judgement, even for a critique of the tradition which is its source. But suppose Trow were right, that history has disappeared, has given way to a series of demographic maps emerging from national interest research. In that case the hermeneutic task of self-understanding, the development of awareness of elements of our history internalized in our subjectivity,[8] would not occur. We would remain as if children, secure in the belief that we were unique and new. Empty of self-definition, we would feel infinitely free and we would *be* infinitely malleable.

This is the freedom endorsed in the image of The Girl. Wherever she occurs (in the advertisements in your department store account, on your car radio or in the magazines at the doctor's surgery), she promises that it is possible to be anyone. She has the freedom of 'no-history' which enables her, being formless, to be any form; enables her, without prejudgement, to choose anything. She *is* infinitely free.

But it is the freedom of a child – of preference rather than judgement –

because its activity is detached from reflective action and aimed instead at agreement in and with the moment of choice. That agreement provides the comfort The Girl needs. She needs comfort partly in order to represent the possibility of our fulfilment and partly because we find in her an echo of our own unease at the increasing difficulty of choosing – a job, for example, or a partner. As the difficulty increases, the importance of these things is transferred to the realm of trivial choices. The Girl represents this possibility as comforting. 'How should we live together?' is replaced by 'What should we look like?' Trow writes:

> important forces that fell outside the new scale of national life (which was the life of television) began to find a home in the exercise of preference concerning trivial matters, so that attention, aspiration, even affection came to adhere to shimmers thrown up by the demography in trivial matters.[9]

In The Girl, this transformation is affirmed for us. She is the epitome of its accomplishment.

Here we begin to see why this structure has been feminine. In order to work on us, in order to offer itself for us to think ourselves through, it must invite without seeming to limit us. It must represent an infinitely receding object (we can never be just like her, for she is always changing), which can then be infinitely appealing. But passive invitation always just beyond reach has been the central structure of sexual purity, of female innnocence in Western culture. That structure has been the condition of being potentially possessable and yet wholly unformed, so wholly malleable. In a Judaeo-Christian culture, such an image is most easily feminine: it needs to be in order to do its job. The rhetorical echo of the femininity of the representation is the structure of sexual purity, resonating under capitalism, in the bare, free object.

What does The Girl represent?

In her history of American housework, *Never Done*, Susan Strasser points out that the change from consumption perceived as wastefulness performed by the idle, to consumption as a necessary profession requiring dedication, efficiency and large amounts of time, was engineered by mass marketing, and that its primary locus was the lives of women. Massive industrialization tended to break apart the bonds of family and community both by means of the practical demands of the mobile workplace and by means of the self-identity it projected: 'corporate products were established as solutions for fearful individuals in a hostile world', which translates, as Strasser says, into the cornerstone of consumerism: 'Money CAN buy love.'[10] Unlovable in a hostile environment, the person becomes an atomized particle of need, feeling, as Trow says, that 'The background is distant, the sense of protection is distant. People are so frightened. There is so much distance between them and their protection. They reward anyone who can persuade them that there is no distance.'[11]

In the face of this separation, which is really a separation from oneself, The Girl is projected as the image of normality and hence as the image characterizing the group. She is offered to us by the media as a representation of the possibility of belonging. As both the abstract consumable and the abstract consumer, she holds out to us both the end and the way. Marx wrote that money allowed every value to be replaced by its negation in the social economy. As money is to the social economy, so also The Girl is to the desire that must motivate a consumer society. In her abstraction, she transmutes every need into an attribute which she can supply. Because in her impotence she stands for power, she *is* 'The image which taps the wells of need and desire'.[12] She is the 'magic and wishfulfillment' that the market may bring.[13] She represents the promise of ecstatic delight with which commodities must be clothed in order to be felt as needs. She represents the perceived and perceptual need, the aesthetic surface felt as need; she is the aesthetic object which we want – bearing no marks of the history of its production, revealing no clues about the lives used to make it. Now, in a post-need culture, the aesthetic surface has become the only feature of the object. Nothing else distinguishes one cereal from another.

Foucault writes:

> Now there is a trait which is common to the economy of pleasures as it functions in the West, namely that sex acts as a principle of measure and intelligibility. For millennia, the tendency has been to give us to believe that in sex, secretly at least, there was to be found the law of all pleasure, and that this is what justifies the need to regulate sex and makes its control possible.[14]

Ironically, history is what allows The Girl to function as an ahistorical 'law of all pleasure'. Because The Girl is the Paris yard of desire, she is the measure of need. She makes desire intelligible by giving it form and she does this by establishing and controlling what is acceptable as pleasure (the feel of a Schick-smooth leg) or as exchange for sexuality ('Give her diamonds. For all the ways they make a woman feel . . .'). She is the standard in the social construct of the economy of pleasure/sexuality. And so she is also the representation of freedom as control: 'only on satin . . .', 'only with Harvey's Bristol Cream . . .' The freedom represented by The Girl is the freedom of choosing among trivial options which offer her a controlled self, one which is constructed and yet available to everyone. Her self is removed from her, then offered back to her at a price.[15] Her childishness mutes the triviality of her choosing and accentuates her availability for us. Available as an option (so easy to be like her), available as a possession (the Grecian bend, the lowered eyes), in her sexuality, she represents freedom as confinement. The fanny proffered, but moulded and bound, compressed into the safety of abstract curves by jeans, size 10. Her availability is empty, since it is not animate sexuality, urgently present, but only one or another brand of jeans. Sex becomes, in the metaphor of The

Girl, the jeans or any surrogate, and so, safely, comfortingly, its energy can be harnessed, confined, engineered, marketed and exchanged.

The Girl represents the goodness of naïvety; she is 'apolitical'. She has no opinions except about herself. This is what makes her normal and normative. She represents little bits of information as interesting: in the 'Life Style' section of the *Tribune* we can learn how to frame our own pictures. Complex or systematic explanations are unintelligible: '*so* intense', '*too* dull'. Her salvation lies not in understanding where she is but in the proper presentation of herself. She is the epitome of self-concentration as virtue. In the narcissism of this structure, The Girl reproduces and affirms a wider social narcissism, the underside of which is a dependence on authority. In The Girl, Vietnam became interesting as an inexplicable American psychosis, not the state-authorized destruction of another land and people. And, in The Girl, Nicaragua cannot yet exist.

Nourished by consumer media, The Girl personifies the containment policy which is directed against any systematic discussion of national political activities. The fragmentation and involvement with trivia endorsed by The Girl recapitulates the maxim that 'the relation of power is reaffirmed in the structuring of information'.[16] She is the figure of our dependence on the authority of those who know, representing it as appealing at the same time as it defines her. She holds out to us the comfort of leaving the decisions affecting our economic and political life to others, and, more than that, she offers the *goodness* of our dependence upon 'the wisdom and restraint of those in power'.[17] In her, politics becomes aesthetic. Her aesthetic choices are represented as if they were political ones; style and colour substitute for political choice: the reds, the greens, black and white punk, earth-mother browns, the rainbow T-shirt. At the same time the virtue of her dependence is underlined. She is a team player, she wears the badge of her team, but she does not coach it. She specifies her narcissism in her style, which, we now see, is at the same time a sort of self-effacement. She needs direction; in doing this she stands for goodness as vulnerability. She needs protection. She is the figure and product of those 'legitimate American interests' requiring protection. In so far as she represents what we fight to defend, it is clear that *that* has the *real* vulnerability of an aesthetic surface. Where democracy is red, white and blue, a Coca Cola in tennis shorts, it *needs* protection. Sheer surface, infinitely changeable and therefore empty, it cannot stand as its own security. As social values are exchanged for an aesthetic, the structure which they legitimate becomes less and less secure. 'All efforts to render politics aesthetic culminate in one thing: war,' said Walter Benjamin.[18] The Girl is a figure of that tendency.

Why?

The Girl is a trick. She is the coin in the exchange of desires. For she is the badge of potency that we all are to want – either immediately (she'll be mine with the car) or mediately (with the car she'll be me). In her operation

she increases the impotence that makes us need her. For, as we enter that structure, we relinquish our history and ourselves. The more we reach for her, the more impotent, alone and fragmented we are and then the more we need her. Thus, the more she sells us, the more she works. If all of our self-concept were up to her, she could sell us anything, endlessly. The ideal circumstance for the market-place would be that the whole context of our self-identification were entirely open. But, for all of us, the context of no context is intolerable. It produces aimlessness and a constant need of comfort. We look to some version of The Girl to provide that complete environment which, reflecting inward, will identify its inhabitants to us as ourselves.

In the void left by the loss of history, The Girl promises power, community and self-control. If only we have her or look like her we will be validated, included, unified. More than that, we will survive, for 'in a world of strangers, survival is a matter of appearance and surface impressions.'[19]

In her femininity, The Girl offers herself to us as salvation; she is so available if only we will reach out. In a society in which power is the prerogative, defining characteristic and source of self-validation for men, but a society in which that power, even over one's daily life, is increasingly closed to *all* of us, what else could the trick be but the ever open, ever nice, infinitely available and always deferred sexuality of The Girl. As we take her, as we learn to perceive ourselves through her, we affirm that fear and money can buy love. Stuart and Elizabeth Ewen write:

> The goal of the advertising industry is to link the isolated experience of the spectator with the collectivized impulses and priorities of the corporation. The contingencies of the *self* will be thwarted by the unity of the commodity and the facts of the market place. In the commodity lies a newly realized self, the promise of community.[20]

The Girl is currency for this exchange: self for commodity. Without her, or something which could do what she does, the exchange could not take place. Through The Girl, corporate priorities are inserted into the smallest recesses of our lives. From sexual habits to cereal, the standards for 'normal' life become the channels of our desire. The mechanism for controlling this flow is the structure of The Girl. As it succeeds, the ideal that she represents becomes part of us. Her homelessness becomes our history. Her childishness becomes our maturity. Her distance transforms our sexuality. Her passivity becomes our authority. Her narcissism appears as our virtue and her freedom becomes our confinement. In her, war appears in the guise of peace, and appearance *is* reality – the necessary shape of consumer capitalism.

St Mary's College, Notre Dame, Indiana

Notes

1 G. Trow, *Within the Context of No Context* (Boston, Mass.: Little Brown, 1981).
2 Ibid., p. 7.

3 E. Janeway, *Powers of the Weak* (New York: Knopf, 1981).
4 Trow, op. cit., p. 19.
5 Ibid., pp. 3–4.
6 M. Janssen-Jurreit, *Sexism: The Male Monopoly on History and Thought* (New York: Farrar Straus & Giroux, 1982), p. 33.
7 Quoted in T. McCarthy, *The Critical Theory of Jürgen Habermas* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1981), p. 180.
8 Ibid.
9 Ibid., p. 7.
10 S. Strasser, *Never Done: A History of American Housework* (New York: Pantheon, 1982), p. 253.
11 Trow, op. cit., p. 74.
12 S. and E. Ewen, *Channels of Desire* (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1982), p. 74.
13 Ibid., p. 62.
14 M. Foucault, *The History of Sexuality*, vol. 1 (New York: Pantheon, 1980), pp. 190–1.
15 J. Berger, *Ways of Seeing* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1972), p. 134.
16 S. and E. Ewen, op. cit., p. 251.
17 Ibid., p. 270.
18 W. Benjamin, 'The work of art in the age of mechanical reproduction', *Illuminations* (New York: Schocken, 1968), p. 243.
19 S. and E. Ewen, op. cit., p. 263.
20 Ibid.